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Integrating online and telephonic conference platforms and enabling screening of attendee questions regardless of way attendee joins

Abstract

A controller of a virtual conferencing system commands an online conference platform to create an online main conference room associated with a meeting, and commands a telephonic conference platform to create a telephonic main conference room associated with the meeting. The controller further commands at least one of the online and telephonic conference platforms to join the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room together so audio is passed therebetween to form an integrated main conference room. A similar process is used to create an integrated screener room. The controller stores a question queue identifying both online and telephonic attendees who have questions. Attendees who have an unscreened question are moved into either an online or telephonic part of the integrated screener room depending on the way the attendee joined the meeting. Moderators move both telephonic and online attendees with screened questions into the main conference room.

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Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS

(1) This application claims the benefit of priority of Canadian Patent Application No. 3,142,130 filed Dec. 14, 2021, which is incorporated herein by reference.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

(1) Field of the Invention

(2) The invention pertains generally to virtual conference systems. More specifically, the invention relates to integrating online and telephony virtual conference platforms to form an integrated virtual conference system and allowing moderators to screen attendee questions regardless which way the attendee joins the meeting.

(2) Description of the Related Art

(3) Telephonic conferencing platforms enabling conferences and meetings between participants in different locations via phone lines are known in the art. Examples of functionality are provided in U.S. Pat. No. 8,385,526 entitled “SYSTEM AND PROCESS FOR MASS TELEPHONY CONFERENCE CALL” and U.S. Pat. No. 8,266,535 entitled “TELEFORUM APPARATUS AND METHOD”. An example of a current well-known telephonic conference platform is Telnix™. One problem with telephonic conferencing systems is they only facilitate telephone-based audio communications and do not allow video chat between conference participants over the Internet.

(4) Online conferencing platforms leverage webcams and the increased bandwidth of the Internet to transfer full audiovisual data between participants. As such, online conferencing platforms are becoming ubiquitous in modern remote-work business and home environments. Examples of some

current well-known online conferencing platforms include Jitsi™, Zoom™, Skype™, Teams™, GoToMeeting™, Google Meet™, and Cisco Webex™. However, being designed for different target markets and making use of different underlying technology, online conferencing platforms do not include all the same features of existing telephonic conferencing systems.

(5) In particular, current online conferencing platforms do not include a methodical way to screen participant questions and smoothly allow them to ask the question in their own words. Especially for town hall meetings, annual general meetings (AGMs), and public-facing corporate and government meetings, meeting staff often need to vet questioners and their associated questions in advance, before allowing the participant to actively be seen and heard by other participants in the meeting. This is an important factor for organizations conducting meetings that need to be transparent enough to allow people to ask questions in their own words, yet moderated to filter out potentially risky questions or questioners.

(6) Another problem with typical online conferencing platforms is that they are focused on online participants with high-speed Internet access and do not support telephonic participants as seamlessly as the older telephonic conferencing systems. Although most online platforms do provide dial-in numbers and room codes that can be entered by touch tones, the administration and management of dial-up participants is secondary to the platform. Functions such as parallel and timed out-dialing of participants, automatic redialing, and touch-tone-based inputs for voting and asking questions, to name a few, are typically not supported.

(7) In general, older telephonic conferencing platforms do not support newer features such as video, and certain functionality of existing telephonic conferencing systems such as participant question screening and parallel out-dialing is not currently implemented in online conferencing platforms. It would be beneficial to replicate the full capabilities of both telephonic and online conferencing platforms in a single conferencing system; however, this would involve significant redundant development effort to duplicate all the desired functionality.

BRIEF SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

(8) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention there is disclosed a virtual conference platform that combines audio/video with telephony/teleconferencing using a method which creates simultaneous instances of one or more conference rooms on both an online conference platform and a telephonic conference platform in a first step and then combines the corresponding conference rooms on the multiple platforms to form one or more integrated (i.e., joined) conference rooms in a second step.

(9) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention there is disclosed an integrated, semi-automated participant question queuing and screening process utilizing an integrated question queue that works for participants on both the online and telephonic conferencing platforms. In some exemplary embodiments, the question queuing and screening process allows for participants' questions to be visible on a conference operator's web-based (HTML) visual dashboard. From there, participant questions can be filtered, upvoted, and positioned in a virtual queue by a 'drag and drop' UI (user interface). This enables participants to ask questions live, and then to be returned to a listen-only broadcast room in an efficient and user friendly manner regardless of from which platform the participant is connected and with minimum disruption to conference flow.

(10) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention there is disclosed a method of creating a virtual conference that combines online audio/video conferencing with telephony/teleconferencing where telephony participants are automatically connected to a web based audio/video conference. Beneficially, the method may leverage existing functionality of the telephone conference platform to connect the telephonic participants to the conference by calling out without required said participants to dial in.

(11) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention there is disclosed a question selection and screening method with a web-based dashboard for question screeners (operators) who can click an "available" button to cause the system to automatically select an unscreened participant and/or

utilize a drag and drop UI to move participants around the dashboard and into private screening rooms and the main conference area of a virtual meeting.

(12) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention there is disclosed a single integrated question queue that allows meeting staff to screen questions from participants on multiple underlying conference platforms—for example, participants who have connected to the meeting via a telephonic conference platform and participants who have connected to the meeting via an online conference platform. In some embodiments, the meetings are secured through a magic link and verified phone participation so meeting staff can hold votes with confidence.

(13) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention, a controller of a virtual conferencing system commands an online conference platform to create an online main conference room associated with a meeting, and commands a telephonic conference platform to create a telephonic main conference room associated with the meeting. The controller further commands at least one of the online and telephonic conference platforms to join the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room together so audio is passed therebetween to form an integrated main conference room. A similar process is used to create an integrated screener room. The controller stores a question queue identifying both online and telephonic attendees who have questions. Attendees who have an unscreened question are moved into either an online or telephonic part of the integrated screener room depending on the way the attendee joined the meeting. Moderators move both telephonic and online attendees with screened questions into the main conference room.

(14) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention there is disclosed a controller of a virtual conferencing system. The controller includes one or more storage devices storing therein a plurality of software instructions, one or more communications interfaces coupled to an online conference platform and a telephonic conference platform, and one or more processors coupled to the one or more storage devices and the one or more communications interfaces. By the one or more processors executing the software instructions loaded from the one or more storage devices, the one or more processors are configured to command the online conference platform to create an online main conference room associated with a meeting and command the telephonic conference platform to create a telephonic main conference room associated with the meeting. The one or more processors are further configured to command at least one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform to join the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room together such that audio in the online main conference room is passed to the telephonic main conference room and vice versa; wherein the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room joined together form an integrated main conference room

(15) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention there is disclosed a controller of a virtual conferencing system. The controller includes one or more storage devices storing therein a plurality of software instructions, one or more communications interfaces coupled to a first conference platform and a second conference platform, and one or more processors coupled to the one or more storage devices and the one or more communications interfaces. By the one or more processors executing the software instructions loaded from the one or more storage devices, the one or more processors are configured to command the first conference platform to create a first main conference room associated with a meeting and command the second conference platform to create a second main conference room associated with the meeting. The one or more processors are further configured to command at least one of the first conference platform and the second conference platform to join the first main conference room and the second main conference room together such that audio in the first main conference room is passed to the second main conference room and vice versa; wherein the first main conference room and the second main conference room joined together form an integrated main conference room.

(16) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention there is disclosed a method of controlling a virtual conferencing system. The method being performed by one or more processors

of a controller for the virtual conferencing system. The method includes commanding an online conference platform to create an online main conference room associated with a meeting and commanding a telephonic conference platform to create a telephonic main conference room associated with the meeting. The method further includes commanding at least one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform to join the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room together such that audio in the online main conference room is passed to the telephonic main conference room and vice versa; wherein the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room joined together form an integrated main conference room.

(17) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention there is disclosed a method of controlling a virtual conferencing system. The method is performed by one or more processors of a controller for the virtual conferencing system. The method includes commanding a first conference platform to create a first main conference room associated with a meeting and commanding a second conference platform to create a second main conference room associated with the meeting. The method further includes commanding at least one of the first conference platform and the second conference platform to join the first main conference room and the second main conference room together such that audio in the first main conference room is passed to the second main conference room and vice versa; wherein the first main conference room and the second main conference room joined together form an integrated main conference room.

(18) According to an exemplary embodiment of the invention there is disclosed a non-transitory processor-readable medium comprising processor executable instructions that when executed by the one or more processors of a controller for a virtual conferencing system cause the one or more processors to perform one of the above methods.

(19) These and other advantages and embodiments of the present invention will no doubt become apparent to those of ordinary skill in the art after reading the following detailed description of preferred embodiments illustrated in the various figures and drawings.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) The invention will be described in greater detail with reference to the accompanying drawings which represent preferred embodiments thereof:

(2) FIG. 1 illustrates a block diagram showing a system for integrating an online conference platform and a telephonic conference platform to thereby form an integrated conference platform according to an exemplary embodiment of the invention.

(3) FIG. 2 illustrates a block diagram of the integration controller of FIG. 1 being a computer server according to an exemplary embodiment.

(4) FIG. 3 illustrates a room correspondence diagram showing how a plurality of different integrated virtual conference rooms for conducting a meeting are formed by joining corresponding conference rooms created on the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform according to an exemplary embodiment.

(5) FIG. 4 illustrates a flowchart of a method of initialization of a new meeting by the integrated controller of FIG. 1 according to an exemplary embodiment.

(6) FIG. 5 illustrates a state diagram showing how an attendee can change between different integrated rooms of a meeting according to an exemplary embodiment.

(7) FIG. 6 illustrates a flowchart of a method of processing an attendee virtually raising their hand to get on the question queue according to an exemplary embodiment.

(8) FIG. 7 illustrates a flowchart of a method of screening meeting attendees with unscreened questions on the question queue according to an exemplary embodiment.

- (9) FIG. **8** illustrates a flowchart of a method of moving meeting attendees with screened questions into the main conference room for publicly speaking with the meeting presenters during the meeting according to an exemplary embodiment.
- (10) FIG. **9** illustrates an attendee user interface (UI) screen with iframe area allowing the integration controller of FIG. **1** to move an online attendee between the broadcast room hosted by the streaming service and the various online conference rooms hosted by the online conference platform according to an exemplary embodiment.
- (11) FIG. **10** illustrates a screener UI webpage for selecting attendees with unscreened questions listed on the question queue for screening purposes according to an exemplary embodiment.
- (12) FIG. **11** illustrates a screener UI webpage for meeting with an attendee in a private screener room and evaluating the attendees unscreened question according to an exemplary embodiment.
- (13) FIG. **12** illustrates a moderator UI webpage for selecting attendees with screened questions listed on the question queue to move to the main conference room according to an exemplary embodiment.
- (14) FIG. **13** illustrates a moderator UI webpage for controlling the audio and video of an attendee asking a screened question in main conference room and moving the attendee back to the broadcast room when they are done asking their question according to an exemplary embodiment.
- (15) FIG. **14** illustrates a room correspondence diagram showing how a plurality of different integrated virtual conference rooms for conducting a meeting are formed by having both online and telephonic conference rooms created on the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform for each integrated room according to an exemplary embodiment.
- (16) FIG. **15** illustrates a block diagram showing a system for integrating any number of different conference platforms to thereby form an integrated conference platform according to an exemplary embodiment of the invention.
- (17) FIG. **16** illustrates an alternative flowchart of a method of processing an attendee virtually raising their hand to get on the question queue according to an exemplary embodiment.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

- (18) FIG. **1** illustrates a block diagram showing a system **100** for integrating an online conference platform **104** and a telephonic conference platform **106** to thereby form an integrated conference platform according to an exemplary embodiment of the invention.
- (19) The system **100** includes an integration controller **102** coupled to the online conference platform **104** and the telephonic conference platform **106**, where platforms **104**, **106** in one example may be the Jitsi™ online conference platform and the Telnyx™ telephonic conference platform, respectively. In many embodiments, the integration controller **102** is coupled via the Internet to these separate conference platforms **104**, **106** and the integration controller **102** may access application programming interfaces (APIs) and/or user interfaces (UIs) provided by these platforms over the Internet. In other embodiments, the connections **108** between the integration controller **102** and the online and telephonic conference platforms **104**, **106** may be via other communication links such as dedicated communication links separate from the Internet.
- (20) In addition to being coupled to external online and telephonic conference platforms **104**, **106**, the integration controller **102** in this embodiment is also coupled to one or more streaming services **110** and a database **112**. In some embodiments, the streaming service **110** may be a cloud-based (i.e., Internet coupled) software-as-a-service (SaaS) provided by a cloud computing provider. Other types of streaming services **106** include video broadcasts such as Cable-Satellite Public Affairs Network (C-SPAN), Real-Time Messaging Protocol (RTMP) streams, radio stations, etc. In some embodiments, the integration controller **102** and the database **112** are implemented by a virtual computer server instance hosted on one or more servers provided by the same cloud computing provider.
- (21) Users of the system **100** utilize personal computing devices **114** such as computers, laptops, netbooks, mobile phones, tablets, etc. to connect with various ones of the integration controller

102, the online conference platform **104**, and/or telephonic conference platform **106** to join and participate in meetings.

(22) As utilized herein, the terms ‘meeting’ and ‘conference’ refer to the same thing, namely, an event where multiple people participate to discuss items of common interest. In this description, the event itself is referred to as a ‘meeting’, while the virtual rooms in which users may be virtually located during the meeting are referred to as ‘conference rooms’. However, it is to be understood that this usage of the terms meeting and conference is stylistic in nature and the terms could be reversed or changed without otherwise altering the system structure and technical operations as described herein.

(23) As shown in FIG. 1, meeting staff **116** such as administrators, screeners, and moderators, utilize computing devices **114** to configure, manage and join a meeting by accessing the integration controller **102**. This may involve the meeting staff **116** computing devices **114** accessing a uniform resource locator (URL) or other network address of the integration controller **102** via the Internet. Likewise, online meeting participants **118** such as online speakers/presenters and online attendees join the meeting by utilizing their computing devices **114** to access the integration controller **102** via the Internet. In some embodiments, meeting staff **116** and online meeting participants **118** may access different network addresses of the integration controller **102** depending on their user type; in other embodiments, the meeting staff **116** and online meeting participants **118** access the same network address of the integration controller **102** and are simply given different functionality by the integration controller **102** according to their user type after being authenticated during a login process conducted by the integration controller **102**.

(24) Rather than accessing the integration controller **102** via the Internet, telephonic meeting participants **120** join the meeting by accessing the telephonic conference platform **106**. Generally speaking, this may be done by either the telephonic meeting participants **120** dialing a phone number of the telephonic conference platform **106** or by the telephonic conference platform **106** dialing a phone number of a telephonic meeting participant **120**.

(25) Lastly, although not utilized in this particular embodiment, it is also possible and therefore illustrated in FIG. 1 that some online participants may join the meeting by directly accessing a URL or other network address of the online conference platform **104**. These user devices **114** are labeled in FIG. 1 as direct-entry online conference platform **104** meeting participants **122**; however, as this direct-entry connection is not utilized in this embodiment, these direct-entry online participants **122** are shown in dashed lines. Further description of other embodiments where online meeting attendees may join a meeting by directly accessing the online conference platform **104** are described later.

(26) FIG. 2 illustrates a block diagram of the integration controller **102** being a computer server according to an exemplary embodiment. The integration controller **102** includes one or more processors **200** coupled to one or more storage devices **202** and one or more communication interfaces **204**. A clock chip **206** such as a real time clock (RTC) is also coupled to the one or more processors **200** to allow scheduling of events based on time of day and elapsed time duration.

(27) The one or more storage devices **202** may include random access memory (RAM), magnetic and FLASH based hard drives, and other storage types to store both software **208** and data **210**. In this embodiment, the software **208** includes a plurality of modules including, for example, a meeting control module **212**, an API interface module **214**, a webserver module **216**, a screener control module **218**, and a moderator control module **220**. Other software modules **222** may be included as needed. The data **210** utilized by the integration controller **102** is organized in this embodiment as a database **112** having a number of tables. Examples of database **112** tables storing different types of information include a meeting rooms table **224**, a users table **228** and a question queue table **228**. Other database tables **230** may also be stored in the database **112** as needed. In this embodiment, a relational database **112** is utilized to implement the database **112**; however, the term “database” as utilized in this description is meant to refer to any stored collection of organized

data **210**.

(28) The communication interface(s) **204** may include one or more Ethernet transceivers for coupling the integration controller **102** to the Internet **232**. As illustrated, the communication interfaces **204** enable the one or more processors **200**, executing the API interface module **216**, to access APIs and user interfaces of the online conference platform **104**, the telephonic conference platform **106**, and the streaming service **110** via the Internet **232**. Other types of communication interfaces **204** may also be included as needed.

(29) The one or more processors **200** may be included in a central processor unit (CPU) of a computer server acting as the integration controller **102**. In the following description the plural form of the word “processors” will be utilized as it is common for a CPU of a computer server to have multiple processors **200** (sometimes also referred to as cores); however, it is to be understood that a single processor **200** may also be configured to perform the described functionality in other implementations.

(30) FIG. 3 illustrates a room correspondence diagram showing how a plurality of different integrated virtual conference rooms for conducting a meeting are formed by joining corresponding conference rooms created on the online conference platform **104** and the telephonic conference platform **106** according to an exemplary embodiment.

(31) In this embodiment, a single meeting includes a plurality of integrated conference rooms including a main conference room **300**, one or more screener rooms **310**, and one or more broadcast rooms **304**.

(32) The integrated main conference room **300** is formed by an online main conference room **300a** hosted on the online conference platform **104** and a corresponding telephonic main conference room **300b** hosted on the telephonic conference platform **106**. These two main conference rooms **300a,b** on the different platforms **104**, **106** are joined together by passing audio therebetween such that audio in the online main conference room **300a** is passed to the telephonic main conference room **300b** and vice versa. The purpose of the integrated main conference room **300** is to host the speakers and presenters of the meeting. For example, during a virtual town hall meeting, a politician speaker and one or more moderator may be discussing various topics with each other in the main conference room **300**. In another example, during an annual general meeting (AGM), executives and board members of a company may report and discuss various corporate business matters in the main conference room **300**. Because the integrated main conference room **300** has audio from both the online and telephonic main conference rooms **300a,b**, participants can join either via an online connection or via a telephonic connection at their preference.

(33) The integrated broadcast room **320** is formed in this embodiment by one-way audio transmission from the main conference room **300** to both an online broadcast stream **322** and one or more telephonic broadcast rooms **324**. Regarding the telephonic broadcast rooms **324**, all audio from the integrated main conference room **300**, which includes audio that originates in both of the online main conference room **300a** and the telephonic main conference room **300b**, is forwarded to each of the telephonic broadcast rooms **324**. The integration controller **102** configures the various telephonic broadcast rooms **324** to be listen-only rooms such that attendees in these rooms **324** cannot speak to each other. In this way, a plurality of meeting attendees may call in to the telephonic conference platform **106** to join one of the telephonic broadcast rooms **324** and thereby hear the audio from the meeting (i.e., from the integrated main conference room **300**) but not speak in the meeting as long as they remain in the telephonic broadcast room **324**.

(34) The broadcast stream **322** is formed by an audiovisual stream from the integrated screener room **300** directed to the streamer service **110** by the integration controller **102**. In some embodiments, the integration controller **102** forwards the video and audio from the online main conference room **300a** to the streamer service **110** because the online main conference room **300a** also includes the audio from the telephonic main conference room **300b** as a result of the online and telephonic rooms **300a,b** being joined. The streamer service **110** encodes this audiovisual input

and streams one or more resulting livestreams **322** as either multicast and/or unicast out to various meeting attendees via the Internet **232**.

(35) Beneficially, the meeting attendees that join the meeting in the broadcast room **320** are not able to interrupt the meeting because audio from attendees in the telephonic broadcast room(s) **324** is not passed to the main conference room **300** and the broadcast stream **322** by its nature is a one-way communication. In this way, attendees in the broadcast room **320**, regardless of the underlying platform (either online or telephonic) from which they have joined the meeting, can either watch and listen to the broadcast stream **322** via their computer over the Internet **232** or just listen to the audio-only portion by calling a telephonic broadcast room **324** using their phone.

(36) In this embodiment, one or more integrated screener rooms **310** are also created by the integration controller **102** to support the meeting. Each integrated screener room **310** includes both an online screener room **310a** created on the online conference platform **104** and a corresponding telephonic screener room **310b** created on the telephonic platform **106**, and these two screener rooms **310a,b** are joined together by the integration controller **102** such that audio in the online screener room **310a** is passed to the telephonic screener room **310b** and vice versa. As will be described further in the following, each integrated screener room **310** is used by a screener user as a breakout room to privately screen meeting participants who may wish to ask a question regardless of the underlying conference platform (either telephonic **106** or online **104**) from which the meeting participants are connected. Each particular screener room **310** allows the meeting attendee(s) and screener user within that particular screener room **310** to hear each other (and see each other if both are connecting via the online screener room **310a**). However, audio from each of the integrated screener rooms **310** is not forwarded back to the main conference room **300** and therefore does not interrupt the main conference part of the meeting.

(37) FIG. 4 illustrates a flowchart of a method of initialization of a new meeting by the integrated controller **102** according to an exemplary embodiment. The steps of FIG. 4 may be performed by the processors **200** of the integration controller **102** executing the meeting control software module **212** loaded from the storage device **202**, for example. The steps of the flowchart are not restricted to the exact order shown, and, in other configurations, shown steps may be omitted or other intermediate steps added.

(38) At a high-level, the meeting initialization process in this embodiment involves creating an integrated main conference room **300** at step **400**, creating one or more integrated screener rooms **310** at step **402**, and creating a plurality of broadcast rooms **322**, **324** at step **404**.

(39) At a lower-level, the creation of the main conference room **300** begins in this embodiment at step **410** by the processors **200** of the integration controller **102** accessing the online conference platform **104** (e.g., via an API or online UI) in order to command the online conference platform **104** to create an online main conference room **300a**. As a part of the creation process, the processors **200** receive a room code being an identifier for identifying the online main conference room **300a** from other rooms that are present on the online conference platform **104**.

(40) At step **412**, the processors **200** access the telephonic conference platform **106** and command the telephonic conference platform **106** to call a phone number of the online conference platform **104** and join the online main conference room **300a**. In this embodiment, the online conference platform **104** includes some limited support for telephonic users such as to call in to a meeting and enter a room code in order to telephonically join a conference room identified by the room code. The integration controller **102** takes advantage of this capability to send one or more commands to the telephonic conference platform **106** to cause the telephonic conference platform **106** to initiate a call leg that calls the online platform **104** and supplies the room code to enter the online main conference room **300a**.

(41) In some embodiments, step **412** is performed by an outgoing call leg from the telephonic conference platform **106** being a session initiation protocol (SIP) connection or other voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP) connection supported by both the online conference platform **104** and the

telephonic conference platform **106**. The room code may be passed via this SIP connection as either parameters or dual tone multi frequency (DTMF) touch tones. Alternatively, in other embodiments, the integration controller **102** commands the telephonic conference platform **106** to initial a call leg being normal phone call by actually calling the phone number of online conference platform **104** like a regular user would and then entering the room code via DTMF touch tones.

(42) At step **414**, the processors **200** determine whether the telephonic conference platform **106** has successfully called and entered the online main conference room **300a**. This may be done by checking result codes or webhooks received via the API of the telephonic and/or online conference platforms **104**, **106**. When successful (i.e., the telephonic conference platform **106** has successfully called and entered the online main conference room), control proceeds to step **414**. Otherwise, if there was a problem or failure of some kind, control returns to step **412** to try again.

(43) At step **416**, the processors **200** command the telephonic conference platform **106** to create a telephonic main conference room **300b** based on the call leg initiated in step **412** that is now joined to the online main conference room **300a**. In this way, the online main conference room **300a** and the telephonic main conference room **300b** are joined together to form the integrated main conference room **300** such that participant audio in the online main conference room **300a** is passed to the telephonic main conference room **300b** and vice versa via the call leg. As a part of the creation process, the processors **200** also receive a room code from the telephonic conference platform **106** being an identifier for identifying the telephonic main conference room **300b** from other rooms that are present on the telephonic conference platform **106**.

(44) At step **418**, the processors **200** save in the meeting rooms table **224** of the database **112** (i.e., stored in the one or more storage devices **202**), an association between the online and telephonic main conference room **300a,b** room codes. These two room codes, one for the online main conference room **300a** and one for the telephonic main conference room **300b**, together identify the two underlying rooms **300a,b** forming the integrated main conference room **300**.

(45) The creation of each of the screener conference rooms **310** begins at step **420** by the processors **200** of the integration controller **102** creating an online screener room **310a** on the online conference platform **104** and obtaining the associated room code. This step is somewhat similar to step **410** described-above, except it creates an online screener room **310a** instead of the online main conference room **300a**. Also similar to as described above, at step **422**, the processors **200** command the telephonic conference platform **106** to call the online conference platform **104** and join the newly created screener room **310a**. At step **424**, the processors **200** ensure success of step **422** and, at step **426**, the processors **200** command the telephonic conference platform **106** to create a telephonic screener room **310b** based on the call leg utilized at step **422**. At step **428** the processors **200** store in the meeting rooms table **224** of the database **112** an association between the online and telephonic screener room codes **310a,b** obtained at steps **420** and **428**, respectively. These steps are similar to the corresponding steps **412-418** described above except being for a screener room **310** instead of the main conference room **300**.

(46) At step **430**, the processors **200** determine whether there are still more integrated screener rooms **310** to create. In this embodiment, the number of screening rooms **310** to create depends on how many screener users will be present during the meeting. Each human screener user may get their own respective screener room **310**. Large meetings with many participants who may ask question may require a larger number of screeners than a small meeting with only a few participants who may need their questions to be screened. If there are more screener rooms **310** to create, the process returns to step **420** to create a next integrated screener room **310**. Alternatively, if all screener rooms **310** have been successfully created, control proceeds to step **432**.

(47) The creation of the broadcast rooms **320** begins at step **432** by the processors **200** firstly initiating a livestream **322** of the online main conference room **300a**. The livestream **322** is made available at a particular network address such as being sent to various attendee computing devices **114** from the network address of the streamer service **110**. The livestream **322** includes audio and

video of the online main conference room **300a**, which is joined with the telephonic main conference room **300b** to form the integrated main conference room **300** and therefore also includes the audio of the telephonic participants **120** in the telephonic main conference room **300b**.

(48) Beneficially, in this embodiment, there are no user limits to the number of online attendees **118** or per-user fees charged by the online conferencing platform **104** for the various online attendees **118** that receive the broadcast livestream **322** like there would be if the online attendees **118** users were all actually joining the online main conference room **300a** as users on the online conference platform **104**. Instead, each user viewing/listening to the livestream **322** merely results in streaming costs from the streaming service **110**, which are typically much lower than the per-user conference attendee costs on the online conference platform **104**.

(49) At steps **434** to **438**, the processors **200** create a telephonic broadcast room **324**. The general flow for each telephonic broadcast room **324** in this embodiment involves the processors **200** of the integration controller **102** at step **434** commanding the telephonic conference platform **106** to call the online conference room **300a** and join the online main conference room **300a**. The room code for the online main conference room **300a** is already known to the processors **200** as it was stored within the meeting rooms table **224** of the database **112** at step **418**. Step **434** is similar to step **412** previously described. The processors **200** then determine whether the online main conference room **300a** was successfully joined (step **436**) and, assuming yes, to command the telephonic conference platform **106** to create a listen-only telephonic broadcast room **324** based on the current call leg utilized in step **434** to join the online conference room **300a**.

(50) To avoid callers in the telephonic broadcast room from interrupting the main conference room, the processors **200** command the telephonic conference platform **106** at step **438** to configure the telephonic broadcast room to be a listen-only room such that new attendees can only listen (receive audio) and cannot speak (send audio) in the telephonic broadcast room **324**.

(51) Some telephonic conferencing platforms **106** have hard limits on the number of attendees that may join a meeting room. For instance, there may be a hard limit of 800 attendees per room. For large town hall or AGM meetings, the number of listen-only users may greatly exceed these limits, thus the integration controller **102** in this embodiment dynamically creates additional telephonic broadcast rooms **324** as needed. Once a prior-created telephonic broadcast room **324** reaches a threshold number of users, the integration controller **102** will automatically create a new telephonic broadcast room **324** utilizing the above steps **434-438** and thereafter reconfigure the telephonic conferencing platform **106** to redirect the room code for the prior created telephonic broadcast room **324** to the newly created telephonic conference room **324**.

(52) This process of dynamically creating additional telephonic broadcast rooms **324** as needed is illustrated in FIG. 4 at step **440** where the processors **200** determine whether the telephonic broadcast room **324** newly created at steps **434** to **438** was created as a result of a prior telephonic broadcast room **324** becoming full (i.e., reaching a predetermined number of users such as 750 users in the case the maximum number of room users supported by the underlying platform **106** is 800 users per room). When yes, control proceeds to step **442** where the processors **200** sends one or more commands to the telephonic conference platform **106** to redirect the old telephonic broadcast room code **324** to the newly created telephonic broadcast room **324**. In this way, the same room code can still be used by attendees to join each subsequently created telephonic broadcast room **324**, i.e., to join the meeting, and this same code will cause attendees to be placed into the most recently created telephonic broadcast room **324**.

(53) At step **444**, the processors **200** monitor the number of users of the most recently created telephonic broadcast room **324** to determine when the room **324** is full. For instance, if the hard limit on number of users per room as supported by the telephonic conference platform **106** is 800, the threshold utilized by the integration controller **102** may be 750 users. Once the telephonic broadcast room **324** has more than 750 users, the room will be deemed to be “full” at step **444** and control will return back to step **434** for the integration controller **102** to create a new telephonic

broadcast room **324** and then configure the telephonic platform **106** to redirect the old broadcast room code to the newly created room **324**.

(54) At step **446**, the processors **200** determine whether the meeting has finished. This may be performed in a number of ways such as, for example, receiving a meeting finished message from a moderator or administrator, when the current time as measured by the clock chip **206** reaches a predetermined meeting end time, or when no underlying rooms **300a**, **300b**, **310a**, **310b**, **324** associated with the meeting have any participants for a predetermined threshold time duration as measured by the clock chip **206**. Any other desired meeting finished conditions may be utilized in other embodiments as desired.

(55) After the meeting is finished, at step **448**, the processors **200** send a plurality of commands to the streaming service **110**, online conference platform **104** and telephonic conference platform **106** to remove the various underlying rooms **300a**, **300b**, **310a**, **310b**, **324** created for the meeting and to stop the broadcast stream **322**.

(56) FIG. 5 illustrates a state diagram showing how an attendee can change between different integrated rooms **300**, **310**, **320** of a meeting according to an exemplary embodiment. Meeting attendees in this embodiment are always deemed to be in one of the following states: in a broadcast room **320**, in the main conference room **300**, or in one of the screener rooms **310**.

(57) The default room for a new attendee joining the meeting would be to entered into a broadcast room **320**. The specific underlying broadcast room **320** will depend upon the way the user joins the meeting—if they join by phone, they will be placed into a telephonic broadcast room **324** and if they join online they will be receiving the broadcast livestream **322**.

(58) At some point during the meeting, the attendee may have a question and may indicate using a user interface available to the user depending on how they joined the meeting. Telephonic attendees **120** may press a particular touch tone key to indicate they have a question while online attendees **118** may type in their question and click a button utilizing a user interface (UI) provided on a webpage on which the livestream **322** is playing in a web browser or other application running on the attendee's computing device **114**.

(59) Upon an attendee initially indicating they have a question, the question will be deemed by the integration controller **102** to be an unscreened question. The integration controller **102** will monitor for the availability of a screener and then, when a screener is available, will move the user from the broadcast room **300** to a particular screen room **310** associated with the available screener. This room move is indicated as state transition **500** in FIG. 5.

(60) The screener then discusses the question with the attendee in the screener room **310** and optionally marks the question as being screened or deleted depending on the opinion of the screener about the suitability of the question and/or the attendee asking the question. The attendee is then moved back into the broadcast room **320**, which is indicated as state transition **502**.

(61) When an attendee with a screened question is selected by a moderator to actually join the main conference room **300**, the attendee will be moved from the broadcast room **320** to the main conference room **300**. This room move is indicated as state transition **504**.

(62) Lastly, after asking their question and optionally discussing the answer with the presenters in the main conference room **300**, the attendee will be moved back to the broadcast room **320** and the question will be marked as having been asked—state transition **506**. At this point, the attendee may ask another question (above-described process and state changes repeat).

(63) FIG. 6 illustrates a flowchart of a method of processing an attendee virtually raising their hand to get on the question queue **228** according to an exemplary embodiment. The steps of FIG. 6 may be performed by processors **200** of the integration controller **102** executing the meeting control software module **212** loaded from the storage device **202**, for example. The steps of the flowchart are not restricted to the exact order shown, and, in other configurations, shown steps may be omitted or other intermediate steps added.

(64) The process starts at step **600** and continues to loop until the meeting ends. In some

embodiments, the start condition may correspond to when the first attendee joins a new meeting.

(65) At step **602**, the processors **200** determine whether they have received a message that a telephonic attendee **120** has raised their hand. In some embodiments, when a telephonic attendee **120** joins a meeting they hear an announcement just prior to joining the telephonic broadcast room **324** that informs them what touch tone key they may press in order to virtually “raise their hand” in order to ask a question. Thereafter, the telephonic conference platform **106** monitors for this tone and, when detecting an attendee as pressed the tone, sends a hand-raised message to the integration controller **102**. The integration controller **102** may also poll the telephonic conference platform **106** to check whether any particular users have pressed the touch tone to raise their hands. As such, the message referred to at step **602** may be received via a push message or pull message from the telephonic conference platform **106**. The message includes a telephonic user identifier identifying the particular user who has now raised their hand (i.e., pressed the predetermined touch tone key to indicate they have a question). When there is a message that a telephonic attendee has raised their hand, control proceeds to step **606**; otherwise, control proceeds to step **604**.

(66) At step **604**, the processors **200** determine whether they have received a message that an online meeting attendee **118** has raised their hand. In some embodiments, online attendees **118** who are in the broadcast room **320** watching the broadcast livestream **322** are provided a user interface including a chat box to type a question and a button to click to raise their hand and submit their question for screening to the integration controller **102**. In response to receiving such a message indicating that a particular online attendee **118** has raised their hand with a question, control proceeds to step **606**; otherwise, control proceeds to step **610** to check if an attendee's virtual hand has been lowered.

(67) For both steps **602** and **604**, the messages received may also be other types of messages and from other sources. For instance, in some embodiments, the audio captured from a participants microphone is fed to an artificial intelligence (AI) or other speech recognition system to analyze what people say when their mic is not live to the conference such as while in the broadcast room. The AI may then determine from the user's speech whether the user has a question or comment. Likewise, a similar process may be performed by feeding participant video from webcam into an AI or other video processing algorithm to detect gestures such as a participant physically raising their hand in order to indicate they have a question. In some embodiments, an AI or other system detects gestures and/or speech from a participant and passes a message to the integration controller **102** indicating whether a participant, either online or telephonic, has a question and is therefore deemed to have ‘raised their hand’ at steps **602**, **604**. Combinations of different methods of detecting participants raising their hands (e.g., touch tones, website buttons, gestures, voice commands, audio signals, etc.) can be used simultaneously in a single embodiment to create messages from different sources at steps **602**, **604**.

(68) At step **606**, the processors **200** look up or create an attendee identifier (ID) corresponding to the attendee determined to have raised their hand at step **602** or **604**. Because there are two independent underlying conference platforms, i.e., online conference platform **104** and telephonic conference platform **106**, each may have different user identifier formats and numbering systems. As online attendees log in and join the meeting, the integration controller **102** may create or lookup a central user identifier for each separate user and store said identifiers and login records in the users table **226**. Thereafter, when a particular online attendee **118** clicks a button on the webpage UI while in the broadcast room **320**, the integration controller **102** may correlate a session ID of the webpage or other cookie value from which the message is received with the user identifier of that online user as stored in the users table **226** at step **606**. Alternatively, when a telephonic attendee **120** presses a touch tone to indicate they have raised their hand, the integration controller **102** may lookup a telephonic attendee ID received from the telephonic conference platform **106** in the message at step **602** in the users table **226** to determine a central user identifier. If there is no central user identifier, one can be created at this step and the association of a user identifier

received in the message at step **602** or **604** with the newly created central user ID may be stored in the users table **226** for future reference.

(69) Table 1 shows an example of data columns that are stored in the users table **226** according to an exemplary embodiment. Other or different data columns may be stored in other embodiments.

(70) TABLE-US-00001 TABLE 1 Example of users table Underlying Conference Attendee User conference platform user ID Type Name platform identifier 1 Attendee Carl Online conference A45-342-422 Mavromichalis platform 2 Attendee Konstantinos Telephonic 443 (Tino) conference Mavromichalis platform

(71) At step **608**, the processors **200** add the attendee ID looked up or created at step **606** identifying the user who asked the question to the question queue table **228**. For instance, Table 2 shows an example of data columns stored in the question queue table **228** according to an exemplary embodiment. Other or different data columns may be stored in other embodiments.

(72) TABLE-US-00002 TABLE 2 Example of question queue table 228 Attendee Question Screener ID Question status Rank comment 1 What is the projected Deleted — Duplicate project cost? 2 Have you considered Screened 4/5 Good but a aborting the project? bit aggressive. 2 How may new people Unscreened — — will be engaged for the project? 1 How will this decision Screened 4/5 Good question. affect share price?

(73) At steps **610** and **612**, the processors **200** determine whether a message has been received indicating that a particular attendee as lowered their hand. For example, a part of the announcement played to telephonic attendees **120** just prior to joining the telephonic broadcast room **324** may include instructions of which touch tone key to press in order to lower their hand. Alternatively, for online users **118**, after clicking a button to raise their hand with a submitted question, the UI may be updated by the integration controller **102** provide the online user **118** the ability to a click a “lower hand” or (cancel question) button. Similar to as described above for steps **602** and **604**, the messages received at steps **610**, **612** may be received by the integration controller **102** from either the telephonic conference platform **106** (at step **610**) that a particular telephonic attendee **120** has lowered their hand, or from the computing device **114** of an online attendee **118** after the user has clicked a cancel question or other hand-lower UI control element on the webpage displayed to the user while they are in the broadcast room **320** watching the broadcast livestream **322**.

(74) At step **614**, the processors **200** determine the attendee ID associated with the particular user to which the message step **610** or **612** corresponds, and at step **616** the processors **200** mark the pending question from this attendee ID in the question queue **228** with an updated status of “deleted”.

(75) FIG. 7 illustrates a flowchart of a method of screening meeting attendees with unscreened questions on the question queue **228** according to an exemplary embodiment. The steps of FIG. 7 may be performed by processors **200** of the integration controller **102** executing the screener control software module **218** loaded from the storage device **202**, for example. The steps of the flowchart are not restricted to the exact order shown, and, in other configurations, shown steps may be omitted or other intermediate steps added.

(76) The process starts at step **600** and continues to loop until the meeting ends. In some embodiments, the start condition may correspond to when the first attendee joins a new meeting.

(77) At step **702**, the processors **200** determine whether there is an unscreened question on the question queue **228**. When yes, the processors **200** determine the attendee ID from which the unscreened question was asked and proceed to step **704**; alternatively, when there are no unscreened questions on the question queue **228**, control returns to step **702**.

(78) At step **704**, the processors **200** determine whether there is an available screener. In this embodiment, each screener screens one question at a time by inviting the meeting attendee who asked the question to join the screener in a screener conference room **310**. As described in more detail with reference to FIG. 10, the screener may indicate they are available by clicking a button on a screener UI webpage that says “Ready for next unscreened question”. Alternatively, the

screeners may indicate their availability for a particular question/attendee by dragging/dropping the particular question/attendee from a list of unscreened questions to a currently screening area on the screener UI webpage. Either of these actions result in one or more messages being sent back from the screener's computing device **114** to the integration controller **102** indicating the availability of that screener. When there is a screener available at step **704**, control proceeds to step **706**; alternatively, if no screener is available, control returns to step **702** to try again a bit later on the next time around the loop.

(79) At step **706**, the processors **200** determine whether the attendee ID who asked the unscreened question selected at step **702** is a telephonic attendee **120** or an online attendee **118**. This is done in some embodiments by the processors **200** looking up the attendee ID in the users table **226** to determine the value in the 'underlying conference platform' column. If the attendee who asked the question is a telephonic attendee **120**, control proceeds to step **720**; otherwise, if the attendee who asked the question is an online attendee **118**, control proceeds to step **708**.

(80) At step **708**, the processors **200** command the online conference platform **104** to create a new user and add the new user to the online screener room **310a** associated with available screener selected at step **704**. As previously mentioned, in this embodiment, online attendees **118** who are in the broadcast room **320** are simply receiving a broadcast livestream **322** and are not actually real users taking up space in any conference room hosted by the online conferencing platform **104**. Thus, in order to move the online attendee **118** who asked the question to the desired online screener room **310a**, the integration controller **102** accesses the online conference platform **104** to create a temporary user account and further sends one or more commands via the API or user interface of the online conferencing platform **104** to cause the temporary user account to join the desired online screener room **310a**. Alternatively, in other embodiments, this step may also be changed to first look up the online conference platform **104** user ID of the user to see if they already have an account on the online conference platform **104**—this can be done by the processors **200** querying the users table **226** based on the attendee ID to check the "conference platform user identifier" column. If the user already has an account, the processors **200** command the online conference platform **104** to move the attendee's existing user account to the desired online screener room **310a**.

(81) At step **710**, the processors **200** move the attendee from the broadcast room to the online screener room. In some embodiments, this is done by passing to the attendee's computing device a webpage including a page element being an iframe having a source address of the new user in the desired online screener room from the online conference platform **104**. As will be described further with reference to FIG. 9, the iframe may be included in a webpage that further includes various UI controls for the attendee around a perimeter of the iframe or adjacent to the iframe. When in the broadcast room **320**, the source of the iframe is set by the integration controller **102** to be the network address of the broadcast livestream **322** so the attendee can see and hear the meeting in progress—i.e., the livestream **322** renders within the iframe. When moved to a screener room **310**, the source address of the iframe is changed by the integration controller **102** to be the new user in the desired online screener room **310a**. The iframe source thereby points to the online conference platform **104** and causes the attendee's web browser to render within the iframe the audiovisual content similar to if a user was joining the online screener room directly on the online conference platform **104**. In some embodiments, the iframe causes an online screener room user interface (UI) for the new user to execute within the iframe when the webpage is rendered by the browser application running on the computing device **114** of the online meeting participant **118**. The content of the iframe allows the attendee's webcam and microphone to be accessed and the attendee **118** can thereafter conduct a mini-meeting with the screener inside the online screener room **310a**. The screener can ask questions and verify information as required in order to screen both the question being asked and the demeanor of the attendee asking the question.

(82) In some embodiments, the integration controller **102** at step **710** further sends commands to

the online conference platform **104** to automatically unmute the attendee's microphone and turn on the attendee's web cam upon entering the online screener room **310a**. In some embodiments, the attendee's web browser will present a question dialog box requiring the user to confirm the turning on of the microphone and web cam as triggered by the integration controller **102** (i.e., to allow the user to authorize the integration controller to control the on/off status of the attendee's webcam and mic). Having the attendee's microphone and web cam automatically activated (with optional user dialog confirmation) is beneficial to avoid wasted time of the screener not being able to hear and/or see the attendee after the attendee enters the online screener room **310a**.

(83) At step **712**, the processors **200** determine whether the screening is completed. This may be done by the processors **200** receiving a message from the computing device **114** of the screener, where the message will indicate either a screening result such as a revised question wording, a grading for the question and optionally a comment, or will include an instruction for the integration controller **102** to delete the question if the question or attendee is not suitable at all.

(84) At step **714**, the processors **200** store the screened question (i.e., the revised question wording) along with the grading and comment from the screener on the question queue **228**. Assuming the question is graded by the screener as being suitable to be asked during the meeting, the question status is also updated to be 'screened'. Alternatively, if the screener determined that the question was unsuitable, the processors **200** update the question status to be 'deleted'.

(85) At step **716**, the processors **200** pass the broadcast room livestream **322** to the attendee's computing device so the attendee can continue to watch and listen to the meeting in progress. Similar to step **710**, this may be done by the processors **200** updating the source of the iframe to be the network address of the broadcast room stream **322** provided by the streaming service **110**.

(86) At step **718**, the processors **200** command the online conference platform **104** to disconnect and optionally delete the new user that was created at step **708**. The disconnection command sent by the processors **200** to the online conference platform **104** ensures that the attendee is no longer within the online screener room **310a** (i.e., cannot listen to or watch the screener screening a next attendee's question).

(87) The deletion of the new user account on the online conference platform **104** may optionally be performed to save resources and possibly expense incurred on the online conference platform **104**. Especially if the question was deemed unsuitable to be asked during the meeting (and/or if the attendee was deemed unsuitable to ask a question during the meeting), the integration controller **102** may command the online conference platform **104** to delete the user entirely. However, if the question and attendee are screened and deemed suitable, then the temporary user account may be maintained even though the user is not currently in any online rooms on the online conference platform **104**. The online conference platform **104** user identifier may be stored in the users table **226** because this platform-specified user identifier will be used later when the user is moved into the online main conference room **300a** when it comes time for the attendee to actually ask their question to the meeting presenters or otherwise speak and be heard in the main conference room **300**.

(88) At step **720**, the processors **200** look up the telephonic conference platform user ID for the attendee associated with the unscreened question determined at step **702**. This may be done by the processors **200** querying the users table **226** to find the value in the "Conference platform user identifier" column for the attendee associated with the unscreened question determined at step **702**.

(89) At step **722**, the processors **200** command the telephonic conference platform **106** to move the attendee identified by the ID looked up in step **720** to the telephonic screener room **310b** associated with the screener found available at step **704**. The screener user themselves will generally be in the online screener room **310a** (hosted by the online conference platform **104**); however, because the integrated screener room **310** includes and passes the audio from both the online screener room **310a** and the telephonic screener room **310b** therebetween, by moving the attendee identified by the ID looked up in step **720** to the telephonic screener room **310b** associated with the screener

found available at step **704**, both the attendee and the screener are able to hear each other and discuss the question for screening purposes within the integrated screener conference room **310**. (90) In some embodiments, the integration controller **102** at step **722** further sends commands to the telephonic conference platform **106** to automatically unmute the attendee's voice audio upon entering the telephonic screener room **310b**. This allows the screener to hear the attendee and is beneficial to avoid wasted time of the screener not being able to hear the attendee after the attendee enters the telephonic screener room **310b**.

(91) To allow easily moving the attendee back to the same telephonic broadcast room **324** when finished screening, the processors **200** may also at step **722** temporarily save in the users table **226** the room code for the telephonic broadcast room **324** from which the attendee is moved.

(92) At step **724**, the processors **200** determine whether the screening is completed. Similar to step **712**, this may be done by the processors **200** receiving a message from the computing device **114** of the screener, where the message will indicate either a screening result such as a revised question wording, a grading for the question and optionally a comment, or will include an instruction for the integration controller **102** to delete the question if the question or attendee is not suitable at all.

(93) At step **726**, the processors **200** store the screened question (i.e., the revised question wording) along with the grading and comment from the screener on the question queue **228**. This step is similar to step **714** previously described and a repeated description is omitted for brevity.

(94) At step **728**, the processors **200** command the telephonic conference platform **106** to move the attendee identified by the ID looked up in step **720** back to a telephonic broadcast room **324**. In some embodiments, the telephonic attendee is moved back to the same telephonic broadcast room **324** in which they were originally located by the processors **200** passing the telephonic conference platform **106** the telephonic broadcast room code temporarily saved for the user in step **722**. In other embodiments, the attendee is moved back to the current telephonic conference room **324** (i.e., the most recently created telephonic conference room **324** at step **438** that has not yet reached its maximum number of users at step **440**).

(95) FIG. **8** illustrates a flowchart of a method of moving meeting attendees with screened questions into the main conference room **300** for publicly speaking with the meeting presenters during the meeting according to an exemplary embodiment. The steps of FIG. **8** may be performed by processors **200** of the integration controller **102** executing the moderator control software module **220** loaded from the storage device, for example. The steps of the flowchart are not restricted to the exact order shown, and, in other configurations, shown steps may be omitted or other intermediate steps added.

(96) The process starts at step **800** and continues to loop until the meeting ends. In some embodiments, the start condition may correspond to when the first attendee joins a new meeting.

(97) At step **802**, the processors **200** determine whether there are one or more screened questions on the question queue **228**. When yes, the processors **200** send information about the screened questions to moderator users—for example, by updating the list on the moderator UI webpage shown in FIGS. **12-13**, for example. Control then proceeds to step **804**; alternatively, when there are no screened questions on the question queue **228**, control returns to step **702**.

(98) At step **804**, the processors **200** determine whether a moderator user has selected one of the screened questions for moving to the main conference room **300**. The selected one of the screened questions will correspond to a particular screened question asked by a particular attendee ID. The moderator may select a screened question from the list shown on the moderator UI webpage shown in FIGS. **12-13**, for example. When an attendee ID with a screened question is selected for moving to the main conference room **300**, control proceeds to step **806**; alternatively, if no attendee ID is selected for moving to the main conference room **300** at this time, control returns to step **802** to update the screened questions list.

(99) At step **806**, the processors **200** determine the whether the attendee ID selected to move to the main conference room **300** at step **702** is a telephonic attendee **120** or an online attendee **118**. This

is done is some embodiments by the processors **200** looking up the attendee ID in the users table **226** to determine the value in the 'underlying conference platform' column. If the attendee is a telephonic attendee **120**, control proceeds to step **820**; otherwise, if the attendee is an online attendee **118**, control proceeds to step **808**.

(100) At step **808**, the processors **200** command the online conference platform **104** to create a new user and add the new user to the online main conference room **300a**. As previously mentioned, in this embodiment, online attendees **118** who are in the broadcast room **320** are simply receiving a broadcast livestream **322** and are not actually real users taking up space in any conference room hosted by the online conferencing platform **104**. Thus, in order to move the attendee who asked the question to the online main conference room **300a**, the integration controller **102** accesses the online conference platform **104** to create a temporary user account and further sends one or more commands via the API or user interface of the online conferencing platform **104** to cause the temporary user account to join the online main conference room **300a** of the meeting. Alternatively, in other embodiments, this step may also be changed to first look up the online conference platform **104** user ID of the user to see if they already have an account on the online conference platform **104**—this can be done by the processors **200** querying the users table **226** based on the attendee ID to check the "conference platform user identifier" column. If the user already has an account, the processors **200** command the online conference platform **104** to move the attendee's existing user account to the online main conference room **300a**.

(101) At step **810**, the processors **200** move the attendee from the broadcast room to the online main conference room. In some embodiments, this is done by passing an iframe of the new user in the online main conference room **300a** from the online conference platform **104** to the attendee's **118** computing device **114**. This step is similar to step **710** previously described except that now the source of the iframe is the URL for the temporary user account (created or looked up in step **808**) in the main conference room **300a**. The attendee's computer **114** now renders within the iframe the video chat meeting interface for their user in the online main conference room **300a**.

(102) In some embodiments, the integration controller **102** at step **810** further sends commands to the online conference platform **104** to automatically mute the attendee's microphone and turn off the attendee's web cam upon entering the online main conference room **300a**. This is beneficial to all the attendee join to the main conference room **300a** a bit earlier than needed in order for them to get ready. Especially in cases where there may be some lag or delay on the broadcast stream **322**, it is beneficial to allow an attendee with a screened question to join the main conference room **300** a bit before they need to ask the question so they can get synced up on the audio and video and ready themselves. The moderator can then activate the attendee's web cam/microphone when it's time for the attendee to actually ask the question. Again, there may be a popup or other dialog requesting the attendee to give permission to moderator to turn on the web cam and microphone. In preferred embodiment, this popup is presented to the attendee upon either entering the screening room or joining the main online conference room **300a** if no screening rooms are active.

(103) At step **812**, the processors **200** determine whether it is time to return the meeting attendee asking the question back to the broadcast room **320**. This may be done by the processors **200** receiving a message from the computing device **114** of the moderator, where the message will indicate the attendee ID to move from the main conference room **300** back to the broadcast room **320**.

(104) At step **814**, the processors **200** remove the attendee ID from the question queue **228**. In some embodiments, the question is not actually deleted from the queue **228** but is instead marked with an updated status of "asked". In this way, the question is removed from the moderator lists of screened questions ready to be asked but a history of the question is still kept for reporting and auditing purposes if needed.

(105) At step **816**, the processors **200** pass the broadcast room livestream **322** to the attendee's computing device **114** so the attendee can continue to watch and listen to the meeting in progress.

Similar to steps **710/716** previously described, this may be done by the processors **200** sending one or more packets to the attendee's web browser to update the source of the iframe to be the network address of the broadcast room stream **322** provided by the streaming service **110**.

(106) At step **818**, the processors **200** command the online conference platform **104** to disconnect and optionally delete the new user that was created at step **708**. Similar to as described in step **718**, the deletion of the new user account on the online conference platform **104** may optionally be performed to save resources and possibly expense incurred on the online conference platform **104**. However, if the attendee ID has further unscreened (or screened) questions remaining on the question queue **228**, then the temporary user account may be maintained despite the user not being currently in any rooms of the online conference platform **104**.

(107) At step **820**, the processors **200** look up the telephonic conference platform user ID for the attendee associated with the screened question selected at step **804**. This may be done by the processors **200** querying the users table **226** to find the value in the "Conference platform user identifier" column for the attendee ID determined at step **804**.

(108) At step **822**, the processors **200** command the telephonic conference platform **106** to move the attendee identified by the ID looked up in step **820** to the telephonic main conference room **300a** for the meeting. Regardless of whether the presenters and other users in the main conference room **300** are in the telephone main conference room **300b** or the online main conference room **300a**, because the integrated main conference room **300** includes and passes the audio from between both the online and telephonic main conference rooms **300a,b**, by moving the attendee identified by the ID looked up in step **820** to the telephonic main conference room **300b**, both the attendee and the various presenters in the meeting are able to hear each other and discuss the question within the integrated main conference room **300**.

(109) In some embodiments, the integration controller **102** at step **822** further sends commands to the telephonic conference platform **106** to automatically mute the attendee's voice audio upon entering the telephonic main conference room **300b**. This allows the attendee to be added to the telephonic main conference room **300b** a bit earlier in order to get synced on the audio (if there is any lag in the other rooms) and to be ready to speak when unmuted by the moderator.

(110) To allow easily moving the attendee back to the same telephonic broadcast room **324** when finished screening, the processors **200** may also at step **822** temporarily save in the users table **226** the room code for the telephonic broadcast room **324** from which the attendee is moved.

(111) At step **824**, the processors **200** determine whether it is time to move the attendee back to the broadcast room **320**. Similar to step **812**, this may be done by the processors **200** receiving a message from the computing device of the moderator.

(112) At step **826**, the processors **200** remove the attendee ID from the question queue **228**. This step is similar to step **814** previously described and a repeated description is omitted for brevity.

(113) At step **828**, the processors **200** command the telephonic conference platform **106** to move the attendee identified by the ID looked up in step **820** back to a telephonic broadcast room **324**. In some embodiments, the telephonic attendee **120** is moved back to the same telephonic broadcast room **324** in which they were originally located by the processors **200** passing the telephonic conference platform **106** the telephonic broadcast room code temporarily saved for the user in step **822**. In other embodiments, the attendee is moved back to the current telephonic conference room **324** (i.e., the most recently created telephonic conference room **324** at step **438** that has not yet reached its maximum number of users at step **440**).

(114) FIG. **9** illustrates an attendee user interface (UI) screen **900** being a webpage including an iframe area **902** with customization source allowing the integration controller **102** to move an online attendee **120** between the broadcast room **320** hosted by the streaming service **110** and the various online conference rooms **300a**, **310a** hosted by the online conference platform **104** according to an exemplary embodiment.

(115) As illustrated, the attendee UI webpage **900** in this embodiment includes an inline frame

element (iframe) area **902**, a question box **904**, a raise hand button **906**, a microphone on-off button **908**, a webcam on-off button **910**, and an audio level indicator **912**. The hypertext markup language (HTML) for forming the online attendee UI webpage **900** may be generated and sent to the user by the webserver software module **216** executed by the processors **200** of the integration controller **102**.

(116) In some embodiments, an online meeting attendee **118** firstly navigates their web browser to a network address of the webserver **216** of the integration controller **102**. The address may be a so-called magic link that include one or more parameters for identifying the meeting to which the attendee wishes to join. The attendee then logs in and is authenticated as a valid user for the designated meeting. Two-factor authentication may be employed by the integration controller **102** to improve security by making sure joining attendees are who they claim to be. Once those formalities are finished, the webserver **216** sends HTML code to the web browser of the online attendee **118** to cause the web browser to display the UI webpage **900** of FIG. 9.

(117) Initially the online attendee **118** is in the broadcast room **320** and therefore the webserver **216** sets the source of the iframe **902** to be the network address of the broadcast livestream **322** for the meeting as provided by the streaming service **110**. In this way, while viewing the UI webpage **900** of FIG. 9, the livestream **322** of the meeting plays within the iframe area **902**. The various other UI controls such as the question box **904** and raise hand button **906** remain available to the user to ask a question while watching the stream **322** in the iframe **902**.

(118) Upon typing a question into the question box **904** and clicking the raise hand button **906**, the webserver **216** of the integration controller **102** receives a message from the attendee's computing device **114** and the processes previously described for adding the question to the question queue **228** (FIG. 6) and for selecting and moving the attendee with the unscreened question to a screener room **310** (FIG. 7) are performed.

(119) To move the online attendee **118** to an online screener room **310a** and allow them to actually see the screener's video and hear the screener's audio, the webserver **216** of the integration controller **102** at step **710** updates the source of the iframe element **902** so that the contents of the iframe area **902** on the UI webpage **900** changes. Specifically, the source of the iframe **902** is changed to the network address of the new user in the online screener room **310a** from the online conference platform **104**. Changing the iframe **902** source in this manner causes an online screener room **310a** user interface (UI) for the new user to execute within the iframe area **902** when the updated webpage is rendered by the browser application running on the computing device **114** of the online meeting attendee **118**.

(120) Likewise, to later move the online attendee **118** to the online main conference room **300a** and allow them to actually see the online main conference room **300a** audio and video, the webserver **216** of the integration controller **102** at step **710** updates the source of the iframe element **902** to the network address of the new user in the online main conference room **300a** from the online conference platform **104**.

(121) Although shown as one UI webpage **900** where the only thing that is changed between different iterations of the screen **900** is the iframe **902** source, other elements of the UI webpage **900** may also be changed as well depending on which room **300**, **310**, **320** the attendee is in. For instance, the online attendee UI webpage **900** may be different for each of the three room states illustrated in FIG. 5. However, regardless of how many different UI webpage **900** webpages are used, in some embodiments each webpage includes a page element such as iframe **902** that has a source that corresponds to what room **300**, **310**, **320** the attendee is currently located. The source of the page element (e.g., iframe **902**) is the broadcast livestream **322** when the attendee is in the broadcast room **320**. The source of the page element (e.g., iframe **902**) is an online screening room **310a** hosted by the online conference platform **104** when the attendee is in a screening room **310**. Lastly, the source of the page element (e.g., iframe **902**) is the online main conference room **300a** hosted by the online conference platform **104** when the attendee is in the main conference room

300.

(122) FIG. 10 illustrates a screener UI webpage **1000** for selecting attendees with unscreened questions listed on the question queue **228** for screening purposes according to an exemplary embodiment. The screener UI webpage **1000** in this embodiment includes two main areas: a first area **1002** for showing information about an attendee currently being screened and a second area **1004** for showing unscreened questions remaining on the question queue **228**. The questions of the question queue **228** are listed in the second area **1004** ordered with the unscreened questions shown on top because these are the question of primary interest to screeners. The order of the unscreened questions on the queue **228** may be changed at any time by the screener dragging and dropping the unscreened questions into a new order within the second area **1004**. If there are multiple screeners working in the meeting, then each screener will see their own UI webpage and, in some embodiments, a change to the order of questions by a first screener user will cause an update to the order of the questions shown for the UI webpages **900** of the other screener users.

(123) To select a particular question for screening, the screener has two options—they can either drag and drop a particular one of the questions from the queue **228** from the second area **1004** to the first area **1002**. Alternatively, the screener may simply click the “ready for next unscreened question” button **1006** to have the integration controller **102** automatically select the top unscreened question from the list. Both of these ways to select an unscreened question and associated meeting attendee for screening purposes are options related to step **704** “screener available?” Once a particular attendee ID is selected for screening using either of these options, control of the flowchart of FIG. 7 proceeds to step **706** for the selected attendee ID.

(124) FIG. 11 illustrates a screener UI webpage **1100** for meeting with an attendee in a private screener room **310** and evaluating the attendees unscreened question according to an exemplary embodiment. As illustrated, after selecting an attendee for screening, either by drag-and-drop or pressing the ‘ready for next unscreened question’ button **1006**, the screener UI webpage **1100** is updated to show a video stream **1102** from the user in the online screener room **310a** (if they are an online attendee **118**) along with UI elements for modifying the question text **1104**, adding a comment **1106**, adding a grading **1108**, or rejecting the question entirely **1110**.

(125) In this embodiment, the screener will always hear the audio of the attendee due to both the attendee and the screener being in the integrated screener room **310**, which includes audio from both the underlying online screener room **310a** and telephonic screener room **310b**. However, in the event the attendee is a telephonic attendee **120**, the screener will not have a video preview **1102** of the attendee **120**.

(126) After discussing the question with the attendee, the screener can update the question text in box **1104** and/or add a comment in box **1106** and then click one of the stars **1108** to grade the question and marked it with a status of “screened” in the question queue **228**. Alternatively, the screener may instead click the reject button **1110** to marked the question with a status of “deleted” (or “rejected”) in the question queue **228**. The attendee is thereafter moved back to the broadcast room **320** since screening is completed (steps **712/724** of FIG. 7).

(127) FIG. 12 illustrates a moderator UI webpage **1200** for selecting attendees with screened questions listed on the question queue **228** to move to the main conference room **300** according to an exemplary embodiment. Similar the screener UI **1000** of FIG. 10, the moderator UI webpage **1200** in this embodiment includes two main areas: a first area **1202** for showing information about an attendee currently asking a question in the main conference room **300** and a second area **1204** for showing screened questions remaining on the question queue **228**. The questions of the question queue **228** are listed in the second area **1204** with the screened questions shown on top because these are the question of primary interest to moderators. The order of the screened questions on the queue **228** may be changed at any time by the moderator dragging and dropping the screened questions into a new order. If there are multiple moderators working in the meeting, then each moderator will see their own UI webpage **1200** and, in some embodiments, a change to the order of

questions by a first moderator user will cause an update to the order of the questions shown for the UI webpages **1200** of the other moderators users.

(128) To select a particular attendee for moving to the main conference room **300**, the moderator has two options—they can either drag and drop a particular one of the questions from the queue **228** from the second area **1204** to the first area **1202**. Alternatively, the moderator may simply click the “ready for next screened question” button **1206** to have the integration controller **102** automatically select the top screened question from the list in the second area **1204**. Both of these ways to select a screened question and associated meeting attendee for moving to the main conference room **300** are options related to step **804** “attendee ID moved to main conference?” Once a particular attendee ID is selected using either of these options, control of the flowchart of FIG. **8** proceeds to step **806** for the selected attendee ID.

(129) FIG. **13** illustrates a moderator UI webpage **1300** for controlling the audio and video of an attendee asking a screened question in main conference room **300** and moving the attendee back to the broadcast room **320** when they are done asking their question according to an exemplary embodiment. As illustrated, after selecting an attendee, either by drag-and-drop or pressing the ‘ready for next screened question’ button **1206**, the moderator UI webpage **1300** is updated to show a video stream **1302** from the user in the online main conference room **300a** (if they are an online attendee **118**) along with information **1304** about the screened question and UI elements **1306**, **1308** for turning on and off the attendee's microphone and web cam, and a button **1310** returning the attendee to the broadcast room **320** when they are finished asking their question.

(130) In this embodiment, when the attendee's microphone is unmuted, the moderator (and other people in the online/telephonic main conference rooms **300a,b** and people watching the meeting on the broadcast live stream **322**) will hear the audio of the attendee due to these participants being in the integrated main conference room **300**, which includes audio from both the underlying online main conference room **300a** and telephonic main conference room **300b**. However, in the event the attendee is a telephonic attendee **120**, the moderator (and other people in the online main conference room **300a** and people watching the meeting on the broadcast live stream **322**) will not have video **1302** of the attendee asking the question).

(131) While the attendee is in the main conference room **300**, the moderator has control over turning on and off the attendee's microphone and web cam utilizing the UI control elements **1306**, **1308** on the moderator screen **1300**. When it is time for the attendee to speak, the moderator can turn on the attendee's microphone and web cam; likewise, when it is not time of the attendee to speak, or if the moderators decides to cut of the attendee, the moderator can turn off the attendee's microphone and web cam.

(132) After the attendee is finished discussing the question with the presenters and/or other attendees in the main conference room **300**, the moderator can click the “return to broadcast room” button **1310**, which causes the integration controller **102** to mark the question with a status of “asked” in the question queue **228**. The attendee is thereafter moved back to the broadcast room **320** (see the “yes” branch of steps **812/824** of FIG. **8**).

(133) In some embodiments, the main conference room **300** is where the speakers are and each screener has a breakout room **310**, which is an internal private conference room where an operator can discuss an attendee's questions with the attendees prior to moving the attendees to the main conference room **300**. For web attendee **118**, the online broadcast room **320** is the livestream **322** of the online main conference room **300a**, and in some embodiments the livestream **322** may be channeled to a streamer service such as Vimeo™ livestream and delivered to the online attendees **118**. For voice call attendees **120**, the broadcast room **320** is a room **324** that attendees can listen to the audio track of the main conference room **300**, and all attendees in this room **324** are muted.

(134) During a meeting, the attendees are not able to speak or ask any question in the broadcast room **320**. To ask a question, they can raise their hands and screeners can interact with them and give them an opportunity to join the main conference room **300** to ask their questions. The question

queue **228** is designed to help in this process. The above FIGS. **6-8** illustrate the question flow according to some embodiments. The question flow can also be by-passed (as configured during setup for either the whole meeting or for one or more specific attendee IDs) if the conference organizer is comfortable with having attendees submit their unscreened questions into the meeting. (135) An attendee joins a meeting in a broadcast room **320**, and the attendee cannot speak in the broadcast room **320**. To speak or ask a question, an attendee can raise his/her hand. The raised hand attendee is assigned to the question queue **228**. The screener set their status as 'Ready' to receive a questioner. When they are set to 'Ready', a questioner will automatically be assigned to their breakout room **310** where the attendee and screener can speak one-on-one to discuss the question. The screener performs a qualitative assessment of the attendee and enters the question into the system via question box **1104**, provides a grade to the attendee, and moves the attendee back to the broadcast room **320**. In some embodiments, this function may be performed with an automated speech-to-text processor or software service. At the same time, the attendee is still listed on the question queue **228**. While the screener status is in 'Ready' status, the next attendee is auto assigned to the screener when the screener finishes talking to the current attendee.

(136) The moderator or producer sees the screened attendee in the question queue **228**, along with the grade and the question of the attendee. The moderator or producer can move the attendee to the main conference room **300** when the attendee is deemed suitable to ask questions in the main question room **300**. When the moderator is sure the attendee's question will be asked, s/he click a 'transfer' button that will move the attendee from the broadcast room to the main conference room. If an attendee has a low grade, the attendee may be removed from the question queue **228** without being granted the opportunity to speak in the main conference room **300**. The screener, moderator or producer can also choose to move the attendee from the question queue **228** to the main conference room **300** without having the attendee pre-screened.

(137) After speaking in the main conference room **300**, the moderator/produce moves the attendee back to the broadcast room **320**. The attendee can then raise their hand again if they have another question and start the process over.

(138) FIG. **14** illustrates a room correspondence diagram showing how a plurality of different integrated virtual conference rooms for conducting a meeting are formed by having both online and telephonic conference rooms created on the online conference platform **104** and the telephonic conference platform **106** for each integrated room according to an exemplary embodiment. In this embodiment, each integrated conference room is formed by a corresponding pair of underlying conference rooms—one hosted on the online conference platform **104** and one hosted on the telephonic conference platform **106**. The two underlying conference rooms are joined such that audio from one is passed to the other and vice versa.

(139) In contrast with the embodiment of FIG. **3**, FIG. **14** is beneficial when there are no extra per-user charges for each user on the underlying conference platforms **104**, **106** and likewise there are no hard limits to the number of users that may be presented in a single room on the underlying conference platforms **104**, **106**. In this embodiment, the integration controller **102** creates and joins the various rooms for a single meeting as illustrated in FIG. **14**.

(140) New online attendees **118** are initially placed into the online broadcast room **320a** by the integration controller **102** commanding the online conference platform **104** to create a temporary user account for the user and then passing a network address for the user hosted on the online conferencing platform **104**. This network address is used as the source for an iframe **902** or other page element similar to as described above when an online attendee **118** is moved into a screener room **310a** (step **710**) or into the main conference room **300a** (step **810**). Whereas in the previously described embodiment, online attendees **118** in the so-called broadcast room **320** were actually just watching a broadcast stream **322** provided by the streaming service **110** not actually in any room on the online conference platform **104**, in the embodiment of FIG. **14**, online attendees **118** in the broadcast room **320** are actually in an online broadcast room **320a** hosted by the online conference

platform **104**.

(141) In FIG. **14**, all online attendees **118** have a user account and are in one of the online conference platform **104** rooms (i.e., online main conference room **300a**, online screener room **310a**, or online broadcast room **320a**) hosted by the online conference platform **104**. The streamer service **110** may therefore be omitted from the system in some embodiments that create an actual online broadcast room **320a** such as shown in FIG. **14**.

(142) In other embodiments, combinations of the rooms and organization of both FIG. **3** and FIG. **14** may be employed by picking and choosing according to application specification user requirements. For instance, a single online broadcast room **320a** may be utilized for online attendees **118** whereas as a plurality telephonic broadcast rooms **324**, each with a fixed number of users, may be dynamically created as shown in FIG. **3** and described in the flowchart of FIG. **4**.

(143) FIG. **15** illustrates a block diagram showing a system **1500** for integrating any number of different conference platforms **1502** to thereby form an integrated conference platform according to an exemplary embodiment of the invention. Whereas FIG. **1** and the above examples only included two underlying conference platforms—an online conference platform **104** and a telephonic conference platform **106**, FIG. **15** integrates any number of conference platforms **1502** in a similar manner.

(144) The system **1500** includes an integration controller **102** coupled to a streaming service **110** and database **112** similar to as previously described. Central meeting participants **1504** (either staff or of attendees) join the meeting via the integration controller **102**. Coupled to the integration controller **102** a plurality of different conference platforms **1502** including a first conference platform **1502a** up to an Nth conference platform **1502n**. Each conference platform **1502** may have their own meeting participants **1506** joining directly through the conference platform **1502**—for instance, first conference platform meeting participants **1506a** join via the first conference platform **1502a** and Nth conference platform meeting participants **1506n** join via the Nth conference platform **1502n**.

(145) The embodiment of FIG. **15** is particularly beneficial to take advantage of different features already supported and provided by a large number of existing conference platforms **1502**. As one example of a possible application, the integration controller **102** may be coupled to a plurality of existing conference platforms **1502** including Twilio™, Zoom™, Skype™, MS Teams™, GoToMeeting™, Google Meet™, and Cisco Webex™. In this way, a single AGM or town hall meeting may be conducted and participants may join the meeting utilizing their preferred conference platform **1502**. Likewise, separate and possibly different features supported by each of the different conference platforms **1502** may be utilized for the integrated meeting thereby allowing a range of different features depending on which underlying conference platform **1502** a particular attendee decides to use to join the meeting.

(146) In an exemplary embodiment, the integration controller **102** commands each of the various conference platforms **1502**, from the first conference platform **1502a** to the Nth conference platform **1502n**, to create a respective main conference room associated with a meeting. The controller **102** further commands at least one of the various conference platforms **1502** to join some number of the other conference platforms **1502** together such that audio is passed between all the respective main conference rooms, thereby forming an integrated main conference room **300**. A similar process may be done by the integration controller **102** to create a screener room on each conference platform **1502** and then join them together to form an integrated screener room **310**. A similar process may be done by the integration controller **102** to create a broadcast room on each conference platform and then join them together to form an integrated broadcast room **320** (like in FIG. **14**)—or the broadcast rooms may be special in that they are streams **322** or separate listen-only rooms copied from the main conference room **300** on each conference platform **1502** (like in FIG. **3**).

(147) To work with the system of FIG. **15**, the flowcharts of FIG. **7** and FIG. **8** generally are the

same with steps **706** and **708** being modified to determine the specific underlying conference platform **1502** to which the attendee in question is joined. Each underlying conference platform **1502** may then have a sequence of steps similar to as shown in FIGS. **7** and **8** to move the attendee between rooms as required.

(148) Beneficially, the integration controller **102** may consolidate functions/features and statistics of the various underlying conference platforms **1502** and also from attendees joining the meeting via the integration controller **102**.

(149) Voting functionality may be included in each of the different conference platforms **1502** and may be handled differently depending on each type of platform **1502**. For instance, a telephone conference platform **106** may allow telephonic attendees **120** to vote utilizing touch tones whereas online attendees **118** may join the meeting via the integration controller **102** and vote utilizing UI controls on a webpage provided by the webserver **216** of the integration controller **102**. The votes from each of the underlying conference platforms **104**, **106**, **1502** and/or from attendees in the online broadcast room **320** watching the livestream **322** (i.e., not actually in any room of an underlying conference platform **104**, **106**, **1502**) are tabulated by the integration controller **102**. For instance, the processors **200** may tabulate votes made by attendees during the meeting at least by accumulating telephone votes received from the telephonic conference platform **106** and also online votes received from the webserver **216** of the integration controller **102**. The telephonic votes correspond to the votes made by the telephonic attendees **120** and the online votes correspond to the online attendees **118** that joined the meeting via the integration controller **102**. In this way, votes may be held during the meeting and all attendees may participate, even though different attendees are joining the meeting using different technology and providers.

(150) Beneficially, custom functionality supported by specific underlying conference platforms **104**, **104**, **1502** may also be leveraged by the integration controller **102**. For instance, custom telephonic features supported by a telephonic conference platform **106** may be utilized by the integration controller **102** to give a better experience for telephone attendees. Advanced features such as parallel and timed out-dialing of participants, automatic redialing, and touch-tone-based inputs for voting and asking questions may all be utilized during the meeting as controlled by the integration controller **102** via APIs with the telephonic conference platform **106** while still allowing more modern Internet and video conferencing capabilities of other online conference platforms **104** to be utilized during the same meeting.

(151) The integration controller **102**, system and integrated conference in some embodiments beneficially allow attendees to join the meeting utilizing the technology (i.e., online/phone) of their choice and may in some embodiments further allow attendees to join utilizing the specific brand of conference platform **104**, **106**, **1502** of their choice.

(152) Although the invention has been described in connection with preferred embodiments, it should be understood that various modifications, additions and alterations may be made to the invention by one skilled in the art without departing from the spirit and scope of the invention.

(153) For example, webpage frames and in particular iframes **902** are described above as being the webpage element utilized to direct an attendee's web browser to different locations such as the address of the streamer service **110** or online conference platform **104**. However, other types of page elements besides iframes **902** may be utilized for this purpose in a similar manner in other embodiments. For example, both AJAX and JavaScript may be utilized to retrieve data and inject it into a page. Certain HTML5 web components may also be utilized to bundle documents from other documents. In general, any suitable page element can be utilized to embed the streaming service **110**'s livestream **322** and/or the online conferencing platform **104**'s video into a page that still includes UI control elements **904**, **906**, **908**, **910** for the attendee provided by the integration controller **102**.

(154) Although the above examples have focused on online attendees **118** joining the meeting utilizing a web browser running on the attendee's computing device **114**, in other embodiments, a

custom software application that is not a general purpose web browser may be utilized instead.

(155) In another example modification, rather than a high-level loop as shown in FIG. 6 for detecting and receiving messages indicating a participant has raised their hand, an interrupt based method may be implemented to perform similar functionality. For example, FIG. 16 illustrates an alternate flowchart of a method of processing an attendee virtually raising their hand to get on the question queue according to an exemplary embodiment. In this embodiment, actions by an online attendee **1600** (e.g., gestures, button presses, voice or audio signals, etc) trigger a message to be received at step **1602** about the status of that participant's hand. Similarly, actions by a telephonic attendee **1604** (e.g., touch tone button presses, voice or audio signals, etc) trigger a message to be received at step **1606** about the status of that participant's hand. (The term 'hand' here indicates a first virtual state of whether the user has a question to ask—i.e., hand raised, or has a second virtual state of not having a question to ask—i.e., hand is lowered.) At step **1608**, the integration controller **102** looks up the attendee (e.g., in the users table **226**) and then determines whether the message indicates the participant's hand is raised. When yes, controller proceeds to step **1612** to add the attendee to the question queue. Otherwise, when no, control proceeds to step **1614** to remove the attendee from the message queue.

(156) In some embodiments, the screening function may be turned off at some point or for certain meetings as a user configurable setting. When the screening function is turned off, online attendees would submit their question by typing it into a popup window. Phone attendees would not have their questions screened. In some instances, an attendee won't go to a screening room at all. For instance, if a meeting organizer does not select screening rooms, a window will pop up and ask the online attendee to type their question in. Phone attendees will not be screened—just placed into the queue.

(157) Although the above embodiment of FIG. 1 has focused on all online meeting participants **118** joining the meeting via the integration controller **102**, in other embodiments, direct-entry online conference platform meeting participants **122** may also join a meeting directly through the online conference platform **104**. For example, in embodiments where there is an online broadcast room **320a** hosted by the online conference platform **104**, direct-entry attendees **122** may simply join this room **320a** in order to attend the meeting. Similar to how telephonic attendees **120** may receive an announcement or other instructions of how to raise their hand by pressing a touch tone, direct entry online attendees **122** may hear a similar announcement or be provided the instructions via written form upon joining.

(158) In some embodiments, there may be a category of users referred to as an observer. An observer user is someone who can view the meeting but not interact—no raised hand, voting or transferring functionality. Observers are limited to observing the meeting in a read-only manner.

(159) Although the above examples have shown joining an online conference room to a telephonic conference room to form an integrated conference room is done by the controller **102** sending commands to the telephonic platform **106** to call in to the online conference room, the joining of online and telephonic conference rooms can be done by either conference platform calling the other. In some embodiments, the room may be created first on the telephonic platform **106** and then the online platform **104** may call in to the telephonic platform **106** and join the newly created room. For example, let one of the online conference platform **104** and the telephonic conference platform **106** be referred to as a first conference platform and the other of the online conference platform **104** and the telephonic conference be referred to as a second conference platform. The one or more processors **200** may command the first conference platform to initially create a first main conference room and obtain a code from the first conference platform for identifying the first main conference room, command the second conference platform to call in to the first conference platform utilizing a call leg and join the first main conference room by passing the code from the second conference platform to the first conference platform via the call leg, and command the second conference platform to create a second main conference room based on the call leg. In this

way, the first main conference room and the second main conference room are joined together to form the integrated main conference room **300** such that participant audio in the first main conference room is passed to the second main conference room and vice versa via the call leg. The same process may be used to form integrated screener rooms **310** and/or integrated broadcast rooms **320** as required.

(160) In another example modification of the above way to form an integrated conference room, conference rooms on two platforms may be first created in an unjoined manner and then subsequently joined. For example, again let one of the online conference platform **104** and the telephonic conference platform **106** be referred to as a first conference platform and the other of the online conference platform **104** and the telephonic conference be referred to as a second conference platform. The one or more processors **200** may command the first conference platform to create a first main conference room and obtain a code from the first conference platform for identifying the first main conference room, and command the second conference platform to create a second main conference room. After the two rooms are created, the integration controller **102** then commands the second conference platform to call in to the first conference platform utilizing a call leg from the second main conference room and join the first main conference room by passing the code from the second conference platform to the first conference platform via the call leg. In this way, the first main conference room and second main conference room are joined together to form the integrated main conference room **300** such that participant audio in the first main conference room is passed to the second main conference room and vice versa via the call leg. The same process may be used to form integrated screener rooms **310** and/or integrated broadcast rooms **320** as required.

(161) Although the above examples of moderator UI webpages **1200**, **1300** have shown moving a single attendee with a screened question into the main conference room **300** at a time, in some embodiments the moderator can move multiple attendees into the main conference room **300** in a single operation. For example, five (or any desired number) of attendees may be simultaneously moved by a single moderator from the broadcast room **320** to the main conference room **300**. Moving attendees in batches may be beneficial to reduce time requirements for the moderator and also give each individual attendee more time for their audio and video to sync up with the main conference room due **300** to the room change.

(162) In some embodiments, while in a screener conference room **310**, the audio of the integrated main conference room (i.e., the meeting audio) may be played in the background at a low volume level. This allows both the screener and the attendee in the screener room **310** to keep listen to the ongoing meeting.

(163) In some embodiments, a deliberate delay may be added along with a message about the delay time left whenever an attendee is moved from one room to another. The deliberate delay may be around five to ten seconds long in some embodiments and the message may be along the lines of “you are now moving to <name of room> in 5, 4, 3, 2, 1”.

(164) During the delay period while switching rooms, the integration controller **102** may cut the audio and/or video feeds of the meeting to the attendee. In this way, the attendee will not be able to hear the meeting for a period of time while switching rooms. Because of the cut, it will thus be natural for the attendee to expect that their audio will not be synchronized from the room they were in to the room they have now moved. Adding a deliberate delay in this manner by the integration controller **102** masks any inherent audio delay or sync issues between the broadcast livestream **322** and the main conference room **300**, for example.

(165) In some embodiments, people who aren't verified when they call in to the teleconference platform **106** are handled in different ways. For instance, if someone calls in to the teleconference side **106**, the integration controller **102** (or telephonic conference platform **106**) verifies that their number is in a predetermined list. If it is not, they are placed into a listen-only mode until they speak with a screener who can verify their identity and legitimacy to join the meeting. Upon logging, they are automatically placed into the queue with the flag ‘Anonymous’. This tells the

screeners to screen that person and verify their identity. They will jump the queue as well so they can be verified quickly. They are then placed back into the teleconference as a regular user who can vote and raise their hand.

(166) The modules and/or associated algorithms shown and described above may be implemented by software executed by one or more processors **200** operating pursuant to instructions stored on a tangible computer-readable medium such as a storage device **202** to perform the above-described functions of any or all aspects of the integration controller **102**. Examples of the tangible computer-readable medium include optical media (e.g., CD-ROM, DVD discs), magnetic media (e.g., hard drives, diskettes), and other electronically readable media such as flash storage devices and memory devices (e.g., RAM, ROM). The computer-readable medium may be local to the computer executing the instructions, or may be remote to this computer such as when coupled to the computer via a computer network such as the Internet **232**. The processors **200** may be included in a general-purpose or specific-purpose computer that becomes the integration controller **102** or any of the above-described modules as a result of executing the instructions.

(167) In other embodiments, rather than being software modules executed by one or more processors **200**, the modules and/or associated algorithms shown and described above may be implemented as hardware modules configured to perform the above-described functions. Examples of hardware modules include combinations of logic gates, integrated circuits, field programmable gate arrays, and application specific integrated circuits, and other analog and digital circuit designs.

(168) Functions of single modules may be separated into multiple units, or the functions of multiple modules may be combined into a single unit. For example, although the above examples have focused on the streaming service **110** being an external service accessed by the integration controller **102**, in other embodiments the streaming service **110** may be provided by the integration controller **102** itself.

(169) Unless otherwise specified, features described may be implemented in hardware or software according to different design requirements. In addition to a dedicated physical computing device, the word “server” may also mean a service daemon on a single computer, virtual computer, or shared physical computer or computers, for example.

(170) All combinations and permutations of the above described features and embodiments may be utilized in conjunction with the invention.

Claims

1. A controller of a virtual conferencing system, the controller comprising: one or more storage devices storing therein a plurality of software instructions; one or more communications interfaces coupled to an online conference platform and a telephonic conference platform; and one or more processors coupled to the one or more storage devices and the one or more communications interfaces; wherein, by the one or more processors executing the software instructions loaded from the one or more storage devices, the one or more processors are configured to: command the online conference platform to create an online main conference room associated with a meeting; command the telephonic conference platform to create a telephonic main conference room associated with the meeting; and command at least one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform to join the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room together such that audio in the online main conference room is passed to the telephonic main conference room and vice versa; wherein the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room joined together form an integrated main conference room; wherein one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform is hereinafter referred to as a first conference platform; another of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference is hereinafter referred to as a second conference platform; and the one or more processors are further configured to: command the first conference platform to create a first

main conference room and obtain a code from the first conference platform for identifying the first main conference room; command the second conference platform to create a second main conference room; and command the second conference platform to call in to the first conference platform utilizing a call leg from the second main conference room and join the first main conference room by passing the code from the second conference platform to the first conference platform via the call leg; wherein the first main conference room and second main conference room are thereby joined together to form the integrated main conference room such that participant audio in the first main conference room is passed to the second main conference room and vice versa via the call leg.

2. The controller of claim 1, wherein: one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform is hereinafter referred to as a first conference platform; another of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference is hereinafter referred to as a second conference platform; and the one or more processors are further configured to: command the first conference platform to initially create a first main conference room and obtain a code from the first conference platform for identifying the first main conference room; command the second conference platform to call in to the first conference platform utilizing a call leg and join the first main conference room by passing the code from the second conference platform to the first conference platform via the call leg; and command the second conference platform to create a second main conference room based on the call leg; wherein the first main conference room and the second main conference room are thereby joined together to form the integrated main conference room such that participant audio in the first main conference room is passed to the second main conference room and vice versa via the call leg.

3. The controller of claim 1, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to: command the telephonic conference platform to create a first telephonic broadcast conference room associated with the meeting; command the telephonic conference platform to configure the first telephonic broadcast room to be a listen-only room such that new attendees cannot speak in the first telephonic broadcast room; and command at least one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform to forward audio from the integrated main conference room to the first telephonic broadcast room such that attendees of the first telephonic broadcast room can hear audio of the integrated main conference room.

4. A controller of a virtual conferencing system, the controller comprising: one or more storage devices storing therein a plurality of software instructions; one or more communications interfaces coupled to an online conference platform and a telephonic conference platform; and one or more processors coupled to the one or more storage devices and the one or more communications interfaces; wherein, by the one or more processors executing the software instructions loaded from the one or more storage devices, the one or more processors are configured to: command the online conference platform to create an online main conference room associated with a meeting; command the telephonic conference platform to create a telephonic main conference room associated with the meeting; command at least one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform to join the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room together such that audio in the online main conference room is passed to the telephonic main conference room and vice versa; wherein the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room joined together form an integrated main conference room; command the telephonic conference platform to create a first telephonic broadcast conference room associated with the meeting; command the telephonic conference platform to configure the first telephonic broadcast room to be a listen-only room such that new attendees cannot speak in the first telephonic broadcast room; command at least one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform to forward audio from the integrated main conference room to the first telephonic broadcast room such that attendees of the first telephonic broadcast room can hear audio of the integrated main conference room; monitor the telephonic conference platform to

determine whether a number of attendees within the first telephonic broadcast room exceeds a predetermined threshold; when determining that the first telephonic broadcast room exceeds the predetermined threshold, command the telephonic conference platform to create a second telephonic broadcast conference room associated with the meeting; command the telephonic conference platform to configure the second telephonic broadcast room to be a listen-only room such that new attendees cannot speak in the second telephonic broadcast room; command at least one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform to forward audio from the integrated main conference room to the second telephonic broadcast room such that attendees of the second telephonic broadcast room can hear audio of the integrated main conference room; and command the telephonic conference platform to redirect a first room code corresponding to the first telephonic broadcast room to a second room code corresponding to the second telephonic broadcast room, whereby subsequent telephonic attendees who input the first room code will be caused to join the second telephonic broadcast room instead of the first telephonic broadcast room.

5. The controller of claim 1, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to tabulate votes made by attendees during the meeting at least by accumulating first votes received from the telephonic conference platform corresponding to first attendees that joined the meeting via the telephonic conference platform and second votes received by a webserver of the controller corresponding to second attendees that joined the meeting via the controller.

6. The controller of claim 4, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to tabulate votes made by attendees during the meeting at least by accumulating first votes received from the telephonic conference platform corresponding to first attendees that joined the meeting via the telephonic conference platform and second votes received by a webserver of the controller corresponding to second attendees that joined the meeting via the controller.

7. A controller of a virtual conferencing system, the controller comprising: one or more storage devices storing therein a plurality of software instructions; one or more communications interfaces coupled to an online conference platform and a telephonic conference platform; and one or more processors coupled to the one or more storage devices and the one or more communications interfaces; wherein, by the one or more processors executing the software instructions loaded from the one or more storage devices, the one or more processors are configured to: command the online conference platform to create an online main conference room associated with a meeting; command the telephonic conference platform to create a telephonic main conference room associated with the meeting; command at least one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform to join the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room together such that audio in the online main conference room is passed to the telephonic main conference room and vice versa; wherein the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room joined together form an integrated main conference room; initiate a livestream of the online main conference room available at a first network address, the livestream including audio and video of the online main conference room; provide a webserver to which a plurality of online meeting participants may connect to join the meeting; transmit a first webpage from the webserver to an online meeting participant; include a first element in the first webpage that has a source address corresponding to the first network address of the livestream thereby causing the livestream to play when the first webpage is rendered by a browser application running on a computing device of the online meeting participant; and include one or more user interface (UI) controls in the first webpage allowing the online meeting participant to interact with the webserver.

8. The controller of claim 7, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to: command the online conference platform to create an online screener room associated with the meeting; command the telephonic conference platform to create a telephonic screener room associated with the meeting; and command at least one of the online conference platform and the

telephonic conference platform to join the online screener room and the telephonic screener room together such that audio in the online screener room is passed to the telephonic screener room and vice versa; wherein the online screener room and the telephonic screener room joined together form an integrated screener room.

9. The controller of claim 8, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to: receive from the webserver a message that the online meeting participant has interacted with the user interface (UI) controls on the first webpage thereby indicating the online meeting participant has a question to ask during the meeting; determine whether there is a screener available to screen the online meeting participant; when determining that there is the screener available to screen the online meeting participant, add the online meeting participant to the online screener room; receive a second network address corresponding to the online meeting participant in the screener room from the online conference platform; transmit a second webpage from the webserver to the online meeting participant; and include in the second webpage an element having a source address corresponding to the second network address of the online meeting participant in the screener room from the online conference platform thereby causing an online screener room user interface (UI) for the online meeting participant on the online conference platform to execute by the browser application running on the computing device of the online meeting participant.

10. The controller of claim 9, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to: receive from the telephonic conference platform a message that a telephonic meeting participant in the first telephonic broadcast room has pressed one or more touch tones thereby indicating that the telephonic meeting participant has a question to ask during the meeting; determine whether there is a screener available to screen the telephonic meeting participant; and when determining that there is the screener available to screen the telephonic meeting participant, command the telephonic conference platform to move the telephonic meeting participant from the first broadcast room to the telephonic screener room.

11. The controller of claim 8, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to: detect that a screener user for the meeting has logged in to the webserver; command the online conference platform to create an online screener user and add the online screener user to the online screener room; receive a third network address corresponding to the online screener user in the screener room from the online conference platform; transmit a third webpage to a computing device operated by the screener user; include an element in the third webpage that has a source address corresponding to the third network address of the online screener user in the screener room from the online conference platform thereby causing an online screener room user interface (UI) for the online screener user to execute by a browser application running on a computing device of the screener user; and include one or more user interface (UI) controls in the third webpage allowing the screener user to interact with the webserver to indicate their availability to screen meeting participants with questions.

12. The controller of claim 11, wherein the one or more user interface (UI) controls in the third webpage includes a button to indicate to the webserver that the screener user is available for screening a meeting participant.

13. The controller of claim 11, wherein: the one or more user interface (UI) controls in the third webpage includes a list of meeting participants that have unscreened questions; and the list of meeting participants includes both telephonic participants that have joined the meeting via the telephonic conference platform and online participants that have joined the meeting via the online conference platform.

14. The controller of claim 13, wherein the one or more user interface (UI) controls in the third webpage allow the screener user to select one of the meeting participants on the list for screening.

15. The controller of claim 7, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to: command the online conference platform to create a plurality of online screener rooms associated with the meeting; command the telephonic conference platform to create a corresponding plurality

of telephonic screener room associated with the meeting; and for each pair of online screen room and corresponding telephonic room, command at least one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform to join the online screener room and the corresponding telephonic screener room together such that audio in the online screener room is passed to the corresponding telephonic screener room and vice versa; wherein the online screener room and the corresponding telephonic screener room joined together form an integrated screener room.

16. The controller of claim 7, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to: receive from the webserver a message from a moderator user to move a particular online meeting participant to the integrated main conference room to ask a question; command the online conference platform to add the particular online meeting participant to the online main conference room; receive a fourth network address corresponding to the particular online meeting participant in the online main conference room from the online conference platform; transmit a fourth webpage from the webserver to the online meeting participant; and include in the fourth webpage an element having a source address corresponding to the fourth network address of the particular online meeting participant in the online main conference room thereby causing an online main conference room user interface (UI) for the particular online meeting participant to execute by the browser application running on the computing device of the online meeting participant.

17. The controller of claim 16, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to: receive from the webserver a message from the moderator user to move a particular telephonic meeting participant to the integrated main conference room to ask a question; and command the telephonic conference platform to move the telephonic meeting participant from the first broadcast room to the telephonic main conference room.

18. The controller of claim 16, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to: detect that the moderator user for the meeting has logged in to the webserver; transmit a fifth webpage to a computing device operated by the moderator user; and include in the fifth webpage one or more user interface (UI) controls at least including a list of meeting participants that have screened questions; wherein the list of meeting participants that have screened questions includes both telephonic participants that have joined the meeting via the telephonic conference platform and online participants that have joined the meeting via the online conference platform.

19. The controller of claim 7, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to tabulate votes made by attendees during the meeting at least by accumulating first votes received from the telephonic conference platform corresponding to first attendees that joined the meeting via the telephonic conference platform and second votes received by the webserver of the controller corresponding to second attendees that joined the meeting via the controller.

20. A controller of a virtual conferencing system, the controller comprising: one or more storage devices storing therein a plurality of software instructions; one or more communications interfaces coupled to an online conference platform and a telephonic conference platform; and one or more processors coupled to the one or more storage devices and the one or more communications interfaces; wherein, by the one or more processors executing the software instructions loaded from the one or more storage devices, the one or more processors are configured to: command the online conference platform to create an online main conference room associated with a meeting; command the telephonic conference platform to create a telephonic main conference room associated with the meeting; command at least one of the online conference platform and the telephonic conference platform to join the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room together such that audio in the online main conference room is passed to the telephonic main conference room and vice versa; wherein the online main conference room and the telephonic main conference room joined together form an integrated main conference room; and tabulate votes made by attendees during the meeting at least by accumulating first votes received from the telephonic conference platform corresponding to first attendees that joined the meeting via

the telephonic conference platform and second votes received by a webserver of the controller corresponding to second attendees that joined the meeting via the controller.
